

Lab Guide: Installing and Launching Nessus on Kali Linux

Objective

Instructions to install and configure the Nessus vulnerability scanner on a Linux system. By the end of these instructions, you will have a working vulnerability scanner accessible via a web interface.

Prerequisites

- Kali Linux (latest version recommended)
- Internet connection
- Sudo privileges
- Ability to download packages from Tenable's website

Step 1 — Update the System

Before installing Nessus, ensure your Kali Linux system is fully up to date.

Run the following commands in a terminal:

```
sudo apt update
```

```
sudo apt upgrade -y
```

A system reboot is recommended if major updates occur:

```
sudo reboot
```

Step 2 — Download the Nessus Installer

Nessus cannot be installed directly through apt; it must be downloaded from Tenable's official website.

1. Open a web browser and go to:

```
https://www.tenable.com/downloads/nessus
```

2. Select **Nessus** and choose **Linux (Debian-based distributions)**.

3. Download the `.deb` package that matches your system architecture (usually `amd64`).

Alternatively, download via terminal by copying the direct download link and running:

```
wget <download-link>
```

(Students should paste the real link from the Nessus download page.)

Step 3 — Install the Nessus Package

Once the `.deb` file has been downloaded, navigate to the directory where it is stored, typically `Downloads`:

```
cd ~/Downloads
```

Install Nessus using:

```
sudo dpkg -i Nessus-*.deb
```

If dependency errors appear, run:

```
sudo apt --fix-broken install -y
```

Step 4 — Enable and Start the Nessus Service

After installation, enable the Nessus service so it starts automatically:

```
sudo systemctl enable nessusd
```

Start the Nessus service:

```
sudo systemctl start nessusd
```

Check service status:

```
sudo systemctl status nessusd
```

The output should show the service as **active (running)**.

Step 5 — Access the Nessus Web Interface

Nessus is accessed through a web browser.

Open your browser and navigate to:

```
https://localhost:8834
```

You may receive a security warning because Nessus uses a self-signed certificate.

Choose **Advanced → Accept the Risk and Continue**.

You should now see the Nessus setup page.

Step 6 — Configure Nessus

1. On the welcome page, select **Nessus Essentials**.
2. Enter your name and email address to receive an activation code.
3. Check your email and enter the provided activation code.

4. Set a username and password for the Nessus admin account.

Nessus will now download its plugin database. This process can take ****10–30 minutes****, depending on internet speed.

Students should wait until the process fully completes before proceeding.

Step 7 — Log In and Launch Nessus

Once plugin initialization is complete, the Nessus login screen will appear.

Log in with the admin credentials you created earlier.

You now have access to:

- Scan templates
- Policies
- Reports
- Vulnerability scan tools

Students may now begin creating and launching scans as instructed.

Completion

Students have successfully installed and launched Nessus on Kali Linux. They can now explore vulnerability scanning and reporting features as part of further labs or exercises.